I said, and I wanted to hear everything that each of them had to say about whatever topic we were considering, whether it involved their department or not, including any reservations they might have about a proposal; this gave me the opportunity to get opinions from a variety of perspectives, not only from the people who might be supporting a certain project or program.

Some people have suggested that both in Sacramento and in Washington my cabinet meetings resembled the meetings of a corporation's board of directors. I suppose that's true, but there was one difference: We never took a vote.

Everyone pitched in and was involved in the give and take of debate, but when the discussion was over, they all knew it was up to me and me alone to make the decision.

I learned a lot during those first few months in Sacramento. I'm sure Jesse Unruh, who wanted to be governor, and other Democratic legislators regarded my arrival in Sacramento as the beginning of a jousting match, with them determined to knock the novice from Hollywood out of the saddle.

It didn't work out that way. But there were plenty of days in those first months when I had to hang on to my saddle pretty tightly.